



OFF-SIDE

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NATIONAL GAMES REDUCED TO A MERE WARM-UP EVENT

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The 38th National Games kicked off in Dehradun on January 28 with the usual pageantry — fireworks, speeches, Bollywood song and dance — all elements that make a sporting event feel less about sport and more like a grand Indian wedding. Prime Minister Narendra Modi was in attendance, alongside Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Dhami, at the Maharana Pratap Sports College in Dehradun.

Over the years, the opening ceremonies of sporting events have become elaborate productions, with State governments spending fortunes to create an impressive spectacle for a few hours, perhaps hoping to distract us from the logistical hiccups that invariably follow.

Meanwhile, real athletes were having a very different experience. The Bengal kho kho and football teams endured 37 hours on a train without proper tickets, forced to sit and sleep on the floor. The basketball players fared little better — crammed three to a tiny room. In Haldwani, where the swimming events are set to take place, officials were still waiting for the Time, Scoring and Results equipment on the eve of competition.

The National Games, which had faded into obscurity, have found a new lease of life since the Tokyo Olympics, with three editions organised in the past four years. This year, events are spread across eight districts in Uttarakhand, stretching from the plains of Dehradun and Haldwani to the hills of Almora, Tehri, and Pithoragarh, even dipping into Haridwar — perhaps seeking spiritual reinforcement. Nearly 10,000 athletes are competing in 35 different sports, chasing 450 gold medals.

And yet, the National Games feel like an afterthought, drifting through the calendar with no clear rationale.

Gujarat hosted them in September 2022, Goa in November 2023, and now Uttarakhand is having its turn in February. The Goa Games arrived so late in the year that hardly any notable athletes participated, with India's leading names enjoying a well-earned rest after a gruelling competition season.

This edition, too, arrives inconveniently in late winter, just as most athletes are getting their bearings for the year ahead.

For Indian track and field athletes, the outdoor season usually begins in late February or the first week of March. Internationally, there is an indoor circuit during winter, but it rarely features in the calendar of most Indian athletes — except for those with sponsorships that enable them to train overseas.

And it is not just track and field athletes who are being dragged into early action in Uttarakhand. The National Games will be the first competition of the season for India's wrestlers, women boxers, and archers as well.

Of course, all athletes must start their season somewhere. But the goal, ideally, is to build towards a peak, usually for the World Championships, which, for multiple sports, take place in August or September, during late summer in Europe.

Yet here we are, in Uttarakhand, at the tail end of winter, where temperatures have dropped to 8 or 9 degrees at some competition venues — perfect weather for wearing three layers but absolutely not for athletic performances.

Officially, these Games remain India's most prestigious domestic competition, but in practice, they have been reduced to a mere warm-up event.